

Southeast Asia



BETWEEN THE SOUTHERN EDGE of mainland Asia and northern Australasia is an area of shallow seas dotted with thousands of islands. On the islands nearest Australia and New Guinea, Asian and Australasian birds mix together. On more remote islands,

such as the Philippines, many unique birds have developed away from contact with other species.

The rich volcanic soils and hot, humid climate in this region have encouraged the growth of lush rainforests, where a huge variety of birds live. Great numbers of birds often gather on the fruit-bearing trees, but they are well camouflaged and hard to see in the depths of the forest. Many people live in this region and much of the original rainforest has been cleared to make way for villages, towns, mines, and farms. This leaves the birds with fewer places to live and threatens the survival of many species.



Deep, hooked bill for ripping open prey.

Greater Philippine eagle
(*Pithecophaga jefferyi*)
Length: 3 ft 3 in (1 m)

Greater Philippine eagle

This fierce eagle glides over the treetops or swoops down from a perch to catch its prey. It hunts monkeys and flying lemurs (called colugos), as well as small deer and large birds such as hornbills. The Greater Philippine eagle is one of the rarest birds of prey in the world because of the destruction of its forest home. Possibly only a few hundred of them survive in the wild.

Flying lemurs (colugos) are a favorite food.

Two very long feathers in the middle of the tail.

The male fans out his stunning wing feathers to impress a female.

HORNBILLS

Hornbills are named after the strange, hornlike growth, called a casque, which many of them have on top of their bills. It is made of a thin layer of skin and bone over a light "honeycomb" structure. No one really knows what the casque is for. It may help one hornbill tell the sex and age of another, or it may make the bird's call louder.



Great hornbill
(*Buceros bicornis*)
This bird has a large, yellow casque and a loud, roaring call.

Helmeted hornbill
(*Rhinoplax vigil*)
The only species of hornbill to have a solid casque, made of a substance like ivory.

Rhinoceros hornbill
(*Buceros rhinoceros*)
Casque turns up at the end like a rhino's horn.

Rufous-necked hornbill
(*Aceros nipalensis*)
This hornbill has no casque at all.

Great argus

In the breeding season, the male great argus pheasant clears his own patch of space on the forest floor, removing every leaf, twig, and pebble. Then he struts up and down, calling loudly to attract a female. If one arrives, he dances in front of her, spreading out his long wing feathers, which are decorated with dazzling golden eyespots.

Great argus
(*Argusianus argus*)
Length: male (including tail) 6 ft 7 in (2 m); female 2 ft 6 in (76 cm)

Nests made of saliva.

Edible-nest swiftlet
(*Aerodramus fuciphagus*)
Length: 5 in (12.5 cm)

Edible-nest swiftlet

Thousands of these swiftlets nest in caves along the coasts or in tropical rainforests. Those that live in caves use cup-shaped nests made almost entirely out of their own saliva, which hardens like cement. The nests are stuck to the walls and roofs of the caves. People collect these nests to make "bird's nest soup," so they have become valuable.